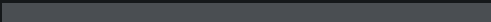


THE 5 LEVELS OF AI

Everybody says you should use AI. Nobody says what that means. **This is the plain English version.** Five levels. Find yours in ten minutes. Then find out what staying there is costing you.

- 05  RUNNING A TEAM
- 04  CHAINING
- 03  BUILDING · THE MONEY IS HERE
- 02  WORKING TOGETHER
- 01  CHATTING · YOU ARE HERE

START HERE

FIVE LEVELS, ONE AT A TIME

Most AI guides hand you twenty apps. The app was never the hard part.

Here are five levels instead. Each answers one question: **how much of the work happens while you are not watching?**

HOW TO USE THIS

Find the level you are really on, not the one you wish you were on. Then look at the next one up.

This guide is the map. What it cannot give you is **which step is yours, and what it is worth**. That part is different for every shop.

Go one level at a time. People who jump from Level 1 to Level 4 land on a mess and a bill.

THE FIVE LEVELS

01		CHATTING You ask. It answers. A better Google.
02		WORKING TOGETHER You hand it real work. It does the first draft.
03		BUILDING It makes you a small tool you could never have paid for. BEST PAYOFF • ALMOST NOBODY IS HERE
04		CHAINING A whole job runs start to finish. Nobody presses go.
05		RUNNING A TEAM You give a goal, not steps. Helpers work at once and report back.

THE SHORT VERSION

Most shops are on Level 1. Almost nobody is on Level 3, the one that pays. Read on and you know your level. Call us and you know your number.

LEVEL 01

CHATTING

A better Google.

You open a chat box. You type a question. You get an answer. No more reading five websites to find one fact.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

- “Write a nice email telling a customer their part is late.”
- “What is a certificate of insurance, and why does my customer want one?”
- “What is a fair late fee to put on my bills?”

WHAT YOU GET OUT OF IT

Real time saved. Maybe half an hour a day, for the one person using it.

But here is the catch. All of it lives in one person's head and one browser tab. Your business did not change. Nothing got built. If that person quits tomorrow, nothing is lost, because nothing was made.

HOW YOU KNOW YOU ARE READY TO MOVE UP

You keep typing the same stuff over and over. Your prices. Your services. How you talk to customers. Every morning you explain your own business to it from scratch.

THE SIGNAL

If you are retyping your business every day, you have outgrown Level 1.

APPS

ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini. Free, or about \$20 a month per person.

SETUP

Ten minutes.

WATCH OUT

Your people pasting customer info into free personal accounts. Most common danger at a small business right now. Also the easiest to fix.

WHAT WE FIND

Almost every time we look, customer info is sitting in somebody's personal account. Finding yours takes one call.

LEVEL 02

WORKING TOGETHER

You hand over real work.

On Level 1 you ask questions. On Level 2 you hand over jobs. Your real files, your real paperwork, your real numbers.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

- Drop in a 40 page contract. Get back the five parts that could hurt you.
- Give it last quarter's numbers. Ask which part of the business is losing money.
- Paste a messy voicemail. Get back a clean work order.
- Show it your five best past bids. Have it write the sixth one, in your words.

WHAT CHANGES

You never start with a blank page again. For a one person shop that is the difference between three bids a week and eight.

It also lifts the floor. Your *worst* work gets better. That matters more than your best work getting better.

WHERE IT STOPS

It forgets everything each time. You still have to remember to use it. Open it. Find the files. Paste them in. Every time.

THE LIMIT

It is a good helper. But it is not on your team. It does not know what happened yesterday, and it will never start a job on its own.

APPS

The paid plans, so you can upload files and save your setup.

SETUP

A few hours to write your business info down once, so you stop retyping it.

WATCH OUT

It can be wrong and still sound sure of itself. Somebody has to check the work.

WHAT WE FIND

There is a short list of things worth writing down once. Most owners guess wrong on the first three. Ask us which three are yours.

BUILDING

It makes you the tool.

Nobody tells small business owners about this level. It is the one that pays the best.

Say you wanted a small tool. A price calculator. A job tracker. One screen pulling three spreadsheets into a single number. You used to have two choices: pay a programmer a lot, or do without.

That is over. Describe the tool in plain words and you get a working tool. Not fancy software. Small, boring software that does one thing your shop needs.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

- A price calculator with your real rules in it, so anyone can quote without calling you.
- A form for new jobs that routes each one to the right person.
- One screen showing money in and money out for the week.
- A tool that reads your bills and flags anything overcharged.

WHY THIS LEVEL IS THE BIG ONE

Levels 1 and 2 make you faster. **Level 3 makes your business need you less.** Your pricing rules used to live in your head. Now they live in a tool anyone can use. That is what lets you hire, take a week off, and one day sell.

THE HONEST WARNING

Anyone can now build something that works the first time. Far fewer can build something that keeps working. Build small. And have somebody who knows computers check anything that touches customer info or money before you turn it on.

APPS

Claude Code, Cursor, Replit, Lovable, and others like them.

SETUP

Days per tool. Not months.

WATCH OUT

Safety and upkeep. Six half broken tools and nobody in charge of them.

THE CATCH

Picking the right first tool is the whole game. Pick wrong and you burn a month. That pick is not something a PDF can make for you.

LEVEL 04

CHAINING

The whole job runs by itself.

On Levels 1, 2 and 3 a person always presses go. On Level 4 something happens and the whole chain runs on its own. You see the finished work, not the steps.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

- A customer fills out your form. The chain looks them up, writes a reply, drops it in your inbox ready to send, and saves them to your list.
- A bill lands in your email. It gets read, sorted, checked against what you agreed to pay, and entered in your books. Anything odd comes to you.
- A job finishes. The customer gets a thank you. Three days later they get asked for a review. The warranty date gets saved.

WHAT CHANGES

This is the first level that removes a whole job, not just makes a person faster.

It is also the first level where things break while nobody is looking. Somebody has to notice when the chain quietly stops working on a Tuesday.

THE STEP PEOPLE SKIP

You cannot automate a job you have never written down. If three people do the same job three different ways, automating it just picks one of those ways at random and locks it in forever.

THE HIDDEN WIN

Level 4 forces you to finally decide how your business actually runs. For a lot of owners that turns out to be worth more than the automation was.

APPS

Zapier, Make, n8n, plus hookups to the systems you already use.

SETUP

A few weeks per chain, including testing.

WATCH OUT

It breaks quietly. Somebody has to own it and keep an eye on it.

WHAT WE FIND

Nearly every business has one job that should be chained first. It is almost never the one the owner names. We can usually spot yours in one call.

LEVEL 05

RUNNING A TEAM

You give the goal, not the steps.

Level 4 is a fixed path. Step one, then two, then three, the same way every time. Level 5 is different. You give a goal. The helpers work out the steps, several at once, and report back.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

- “Find every property manager within 20 miles. Find who makes the decisions. Write a message for each one. Put it in a list for me to say yes or no to.”
- Several helpers at once: one watching email and calendar, one keeping records matched up, one watching your numbers for anything strange. Each comes to you only when a person really has to decide.

THE HONEST TRUTH ABOUT THIS LEVEL

It is real and it works. But it is new. It needs clean records, systems that already work, and a person who checks on it.

The businesses getting real value here did Levels 3 and 4 properly first. Point a helper like this at a messy business and all you get is a bigger mess, faster, for more money.

IF YOU ARE ON LEVEL 1

This is not your next move. It is the move after the two you have not made yet.

APPS

Newer helper platforms. Often built custom for the business.

SETUP

Ongoing. This is a habit, not a one time project.

WATCH OUT

The biggest risk of all five levels. If it can act on its own, it needs limits, records, and a person watching.

BEFORE YOU TRY

There is a short readiness test for this level. Most shops do not pass it yet. It takes about ten minutes to run yours.

TWO MINUTES

SO WHERE ARE YOU?

Be honest. The question is not “has anyone here ever tried it once.” The question is “is this how we work on a normal Tuesday.”

- ☐ 01 Someone here uses an AI chat box most days instead of searching the web.
- ☐ 02 We hand it real work, our files and our paperwork, and we use what comes back.
- ☐ 03 There is at least one tool running in this business that AI helped us build.
- ☐ 04 There is at least one job that finishes without anybody pressing go.
- ☐ 05 We give goals, not steps. We check the results.

HOW TO SCORE IT

Your real level is the highest box you checked where every box below it is checked too. Skipped levels are why most of these projects quietly die.

WHAT MOVING UP IS USUALLY WORTH

For a shop with 5 to 50 people, going from Level 1 to Level 3 usually saves **five to fifteen hours a week** across the team. Your number will not be that number. It depends on your jobs and your people.

But the bigger win is this: what used to live in people's heads now lives in tools your business owns. That is the part that makes a business worth something.

THE MISSING PIECE

This page tells you your level. It does not tell you what staying there costs every month. That is the first thing we work out on a call, and it is usually bigger than owners expect.

CHECKED 0 TO 1 Start at Level 2. You are leaving easy time on the table.

CHECKED 2 Level 3 is your move, the biggest one in this guide.

CHECKED 3+ You are ahead of nearly everyone. Now it needs looking after.

THE NEXT STEP

YOU KNOW YOUR LEVEL. NOW GET YOUR NUMBER.

Everything here you can do on your own, and you should start today. What a guide cannot give you is which move is yours and what it is worth. That takes twenty minutes with us.

START THESE THREE YOURSELF, TODAY

- **Find out where your info is going.** Ask your team which AI apps they use and on what accounts. Most owners are surprised.
- **Pick the thing that annoys you every week.** Not the biggest problem. The one that keeps coming back.
- **Write down how one job gets done.** One page. What you would hand a new hire.

All three are free and they work. They are also the easy part.

WHAT A GUIDE CANNOT TELL YOU: THE AUDIT

- **Your real level,** and the one thing holding you at it. It is rarely what the owner guesses.
- **What staying there costs you per month.** A real number for your business, not an average.
- **Your first build.** The one tool worth making first, and the ones to skip.
- **Where your customer info is sitting right now.** We have never looked and found nothing.
- A written plan you keep either way. Flat fee, agreed up front. No hourly.

BUILD

We make the tool. We write down how it works and hand it over. No black boxes.

EMBED

We stay on and look after the AI side of your business, like we would a network.

TWENTY MINUTES. BRING YOUR LEVEL.

Tell us the number you checked on the last page. We will tell you what we usually find at that level, and what it costs shops like yours. Free, whether or not you hire us.

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